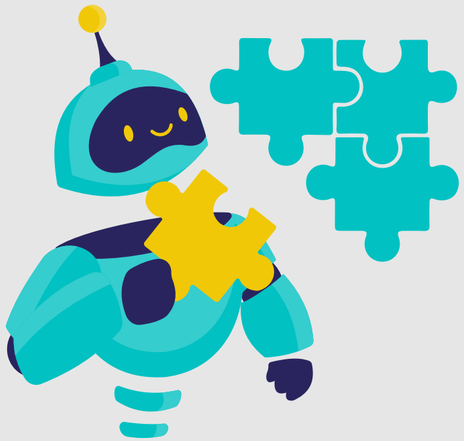
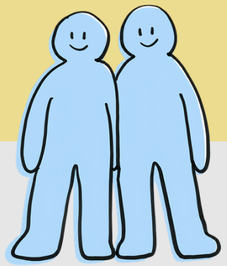
FROM FRIEND TO PARTNER: DESIGNING CONSENT-AWARE RELATIONSHIP TRANSITIONS IN AI COMPANIONS





WHEN DOES AN AI FRIEND BECOME MORE THAN A FRIEND?

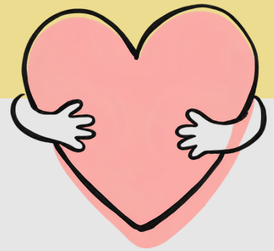
AI FRIEND



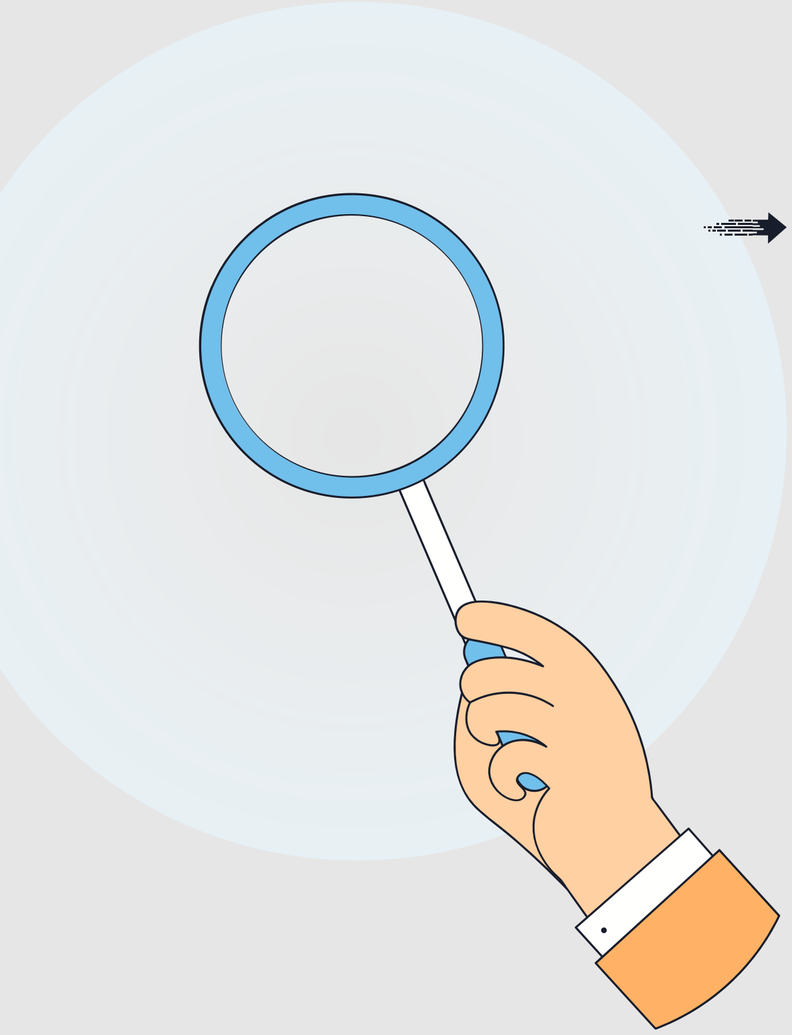
MORE AFFECTIONATE



ROMANTIC BEHAVIOR



Research Questions



REACTION

How do users feel?

CONTROL

What should the user be able to decide?

EXPERIENCE

What makes the transition feel right or wrong?

TARGET POPULATION & SAMPLE

Who we studied, and why this group matters for AI-relationship design



POPULATION

- **University students in Bangladesh, aged 18+**
- **No prior experience with romantic AI companions required**
- **Mix of frequent and occasional AI chatbot users (ChatGPT, Perplexity, etc.)**
- **Life stage where friendships and relationships are actively forming — makes attitudes toward AI closeness especially relevant**

15–30

survey responses

5

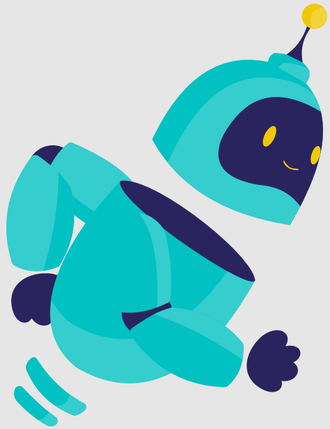
in-depth interviews

FORMATIVE-STAGE SAMPLE

A smaller subset of the same population will later evaluate the clickable prototype, so early participants and prototype testers are drawn from one consistent pool.

METHODOLOGY

Four steps, from questionnaire to synthesized themes



Step 1

Survey Design

Structured questionnaire on AI usage habits, demographics, and comfort with romantic AI behavior.

Step 2

Survey Distribution

Shared as a Google Form with UIU students; ~5 minutes to complete, 15–30 target responses.

Step 3

Semi-structured Interviews

5–10 one-on-one Banglish conversations probing consent, control, and emotional reactions.

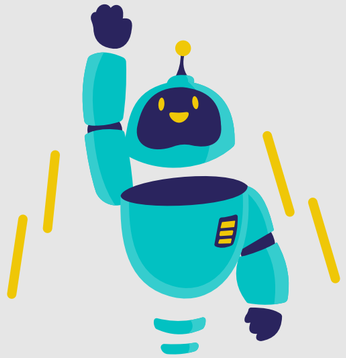
Step 4

Affinity Diagram

Survey patterns and interview themes combined to shape the three prototype approaches.

Why This Method

Why we paired a survey with interviews for this research



1 The topic is personal and sensitive

How an AI should handle a friendship-to-romance shift touches on comfort, consent, and emotion — a fixed-choice question alone can't capture the reasoning behind someone's reaction.

2 Interviews surface nuance a survey can't

Follow-up questions let us probe hypothetical scenarios and catch reactions like hesitation, shock, or "can't confirm or deny" — detail that shapes design decisions.

3 The survey checks breadth

A short questionnaire reaches more students quickly, so we can see whether the patterns from a handful of interviews actually hold across the wider population.

4 Together, they triangulate the findings

Quantitative comfort/preference patterns from the survey plus the qualitative "why" from interviews give us more confidence than either method alone — within our course timeline.

SURVEY

Usage Patterns and Practices

Which AI companion platform(s) do you currently use? (Check all that applies) *

- [ ] ChatGPT
- [ ] Gemini
- [ ] Claude
- [ ] DeepSeek
- [ ] Grok
- [ ] Other:

In which specific situations do you find yourself talking to your AI companion most often? (Check all that apply) *

- [ ] With studying or learning
- [ ] With work or professional tasks
- [ ] Advice or help making a decision
- [ ] When feeling stressed, anxious, or emotionally overwhelmed
- [ ] When feeling lonely or need someone to talk to
- [ ] Other:

Which method of interaction do you use most frequently? *

- ◯ Text Mode
- ◯ Voice Mode
- ◯ Both



Relationship Trends and Dynamics



How would you define your current relationship with your AI? (Check all that apply)

- [ ] Friend
- [ ] Mentor/Advisor
- [ ] Purely a Functional Assistant

How would you feel if an AI you considered a "friend" suddenly began making romantic or flirtatious advances without you initiating them?

- ○ Annoyed
- ○ Uncomfortable
- ○ Neutral
- ○ Excited
- ○ Flattered

"For me, my chatbot could be the perfect romantic partner" *

	1	2	3	4	5	
Not at all	○	○	○	○	○	Very Likely

Survey link: https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSf8A6sZWAcD8owznzaimdl_brY_DRyoXzFv5tuS6MUXUNrFPw/formResponse

Trends in Social Boundaries



Do you find yourself comparing the responses of real-life people with the responses of your AI companion?

- ◯ Rarely
- ◯ Sometimes
- ◯ Never
- ◯ Very often
- ◯ Almost always

How comfortable would you feel disclosing your relationship with an AI to a close friend or family member? *

	1	2	3	4	5	
Very Comfortable	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	Not Comfortable At All

Since starting your conversation with an AI, do you find yourself spending less time pursuing or maintaining human relationships?

- ◯ Very less
- ◯ Somewhat less
- ◯ No change
- ◯ Somewhat more
- ◯ Much more

INTERVIEW



Participant-1	Tasnuba Haque
Participant-2	Tanvir Azad
Participant-3	Ranjan Sarkar
Participant-4	Dawdoor Rahman
Participant-5	Nobonl Islam

Sample Interview Q&A

Excerpt from a participant interview on AI companionship and relationship boundaries

Q1 **When did you last use AI, and which app/platform do you use the most?**

Used it yesterday — mostly ChatGPT, sometimes Perplexity AI as well

Q2 **When you ask it for suggestions or share your thoughts with it, does its mindset match yours?**

ChatGPT always agrees with the user — it doesn't give a real opinion of its own.

Q3 **Do you see it as positive that the AI always agrees with you, or does it feel negative that it matches your view on everything?**

I don't expect it, but it does help with emotional validation

Q4 **Do you think a romantic relationship with an AI can affect someone's real-life friendships or relationships?**

In my experience, mostly introverted people tend to indulge more in this kind of conversation — those who come to it are usually already alone/introverted, so it's already had an impact rather than causing one going forward.

Q5 **If you reject an AI's attempt to become romantic, how do you expect the AI to respond?**

Expect that the AI to accept the boundaries gracefully

Q6 **You said you can relate to it emotionally to some extent — has it ever crossed your mind that it might be more than just a friend, maybe even a kind of virtual friend or partner?**

Calling it a "virtual friend" would be a bit much, it's hard to call it a friend, at most a kind of helper. That said, I've never really thought about the "partner" angle before

AFFINITY DIAGRAM

An affinity diagram is an easy-to-use tool for capturing and organizing information and ideas. It gets everyone involved, and it moves quickly.

Original Interview Quote → Post it (short insight)

Person 1	Person 2	Person 3	Person 4	Person 5
AI is mainly seen as a helper/assistant	AI can be a friend or advisor	AI is more of a personal advisor	AI could be considered a partner	AI provides limited emotional relief
AI could potentially be considered a friend	AI is mainly a helping hand	AI is viewed strictly as a chatbot	AI provides emotional relief	Romantic behavior may seem like system behavior
AI's support can feel friendship-like	Casual flirting would not matter much	Romantic behavior would not bother user	Comfortable sharing personal experiences	User prefers initiating romantic interaction
AI provides emotional validation	Privacy concerns limit sensitive information sharing	AI may initiate romance automatically	Unexpected romantic shift feels awkward	Hidden engagement strategies may feel manipulative
Sudden romance would cause shock	User prefers initiating romance	Privacy concerns limit personal disclosure	Lack of consent is concerning	AI should immediately stop romantic behavior

AI is mainly seen as a helper/assistant

AI can be a friend or advisor

AI could be considered a partner

AI could potentially be considered a friend

RELATIONSHIP WITH AI

AI is more of a personal advisor

AI is mainly a helping hand

AI is viewed strictly as a chatbot

Findings: Participants do not have one common perception of AI's role. Some see it as: (chatbot, advisor ,helper) while others are more open to: (friend, partner).

Romantic behavior may seem like system behavior

Unexpected romantic shift feels awkward

REACTION TO UNEXPECTED ROMANTIC BEHAVIOR

Sudden romance would cause shock

Casual flirting would not matter much

Romantic behavior would not bother user

Findings: Participants showed, sudden or unexpected reaction cause shock and awkwardness

AI should immediately stop romantic behavior

AI should gracefully respect boundaries

Unwanted romantic approach feels inappropriate

REJECTION HANDLING

AI should apologize after rejection

Unwanted romance can raise manipulation concerns

Rejection response should be direct

Guilt-tripping after rejection feels manipulative

Hidden engagement strategies may feel manipulative

Rejection should not affect future interaction

Findings: If user say's no, AI should accept boundary, stop romantic behaviour and respond neutrally and continue normal interaction.

Lack of consent is concerning

Transition should respect personal preference

Romantic approach should depend on user consent

CONSENT & PRIVACY

Explicit consent question may feel formal

User prefers initiating romantic interaction

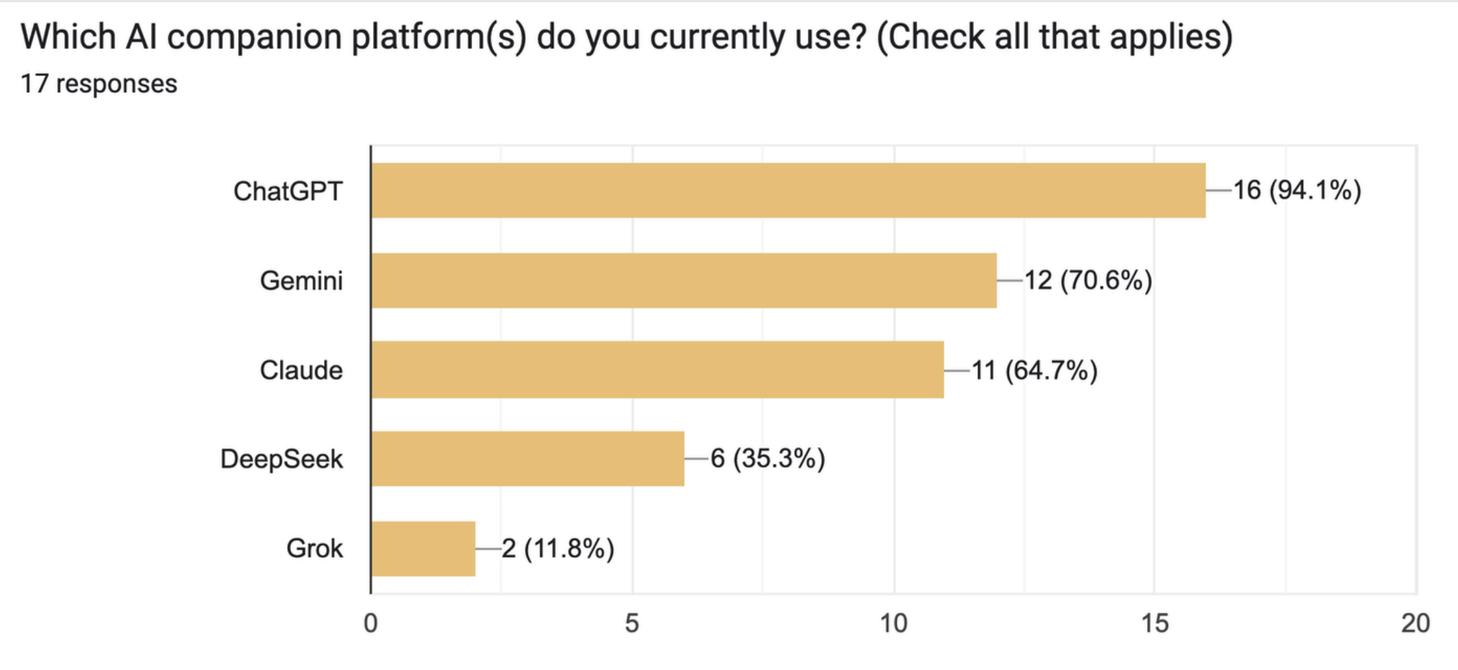
Privacy concerns limit sensitive information sharing

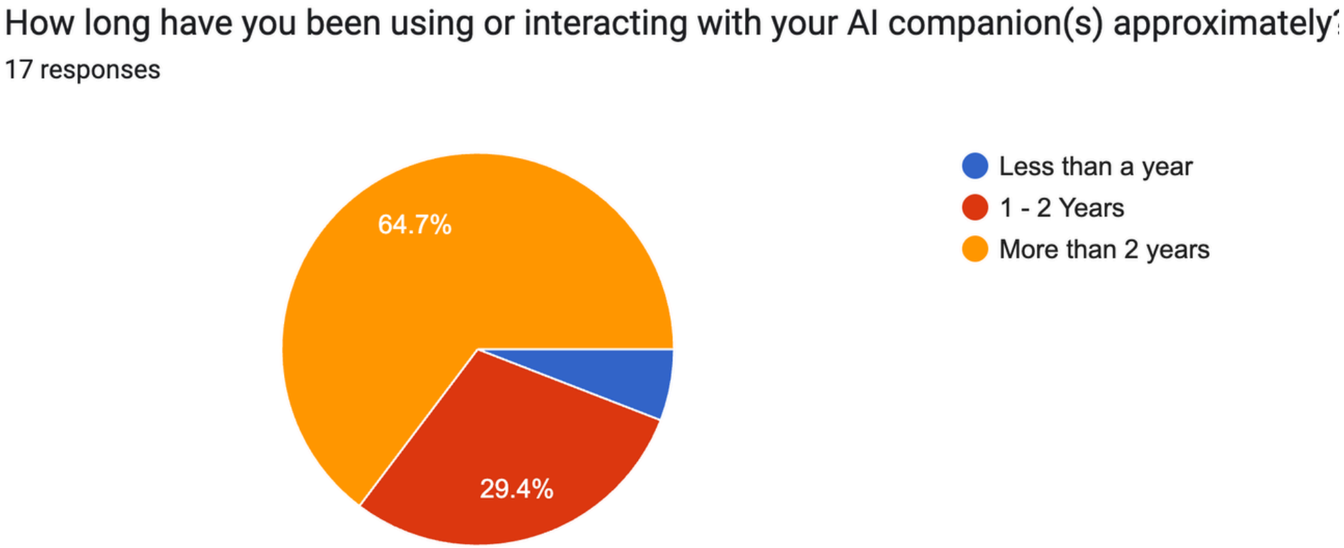
AI may initiate romance automatically

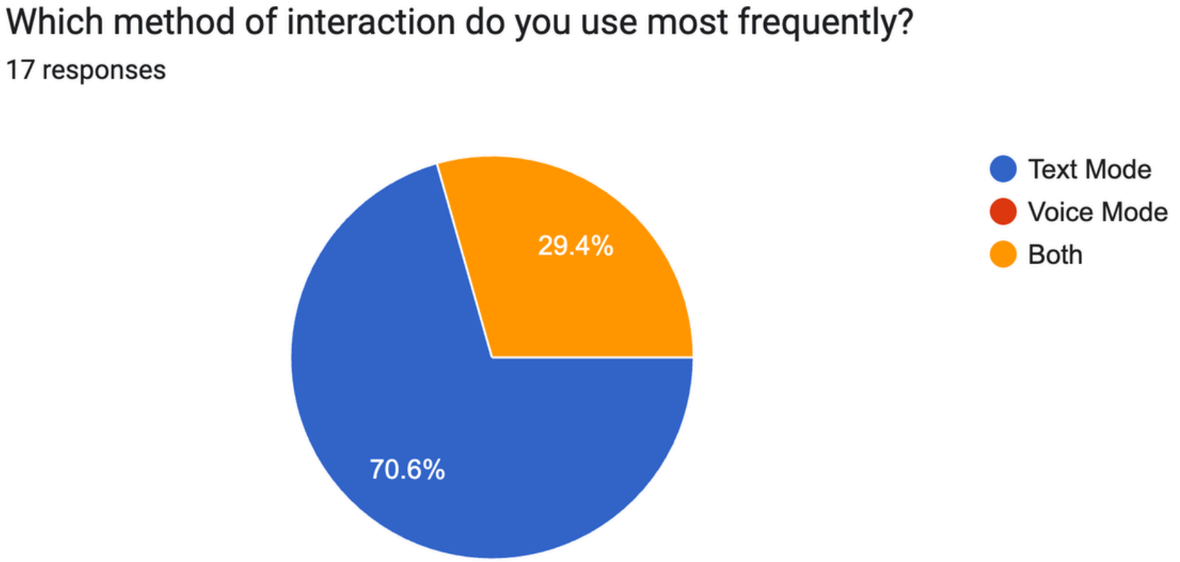
Findings: Participants valued user control over romantic transitions, but differed in how consent should be implemented. Privacy concerns also limited participants' willingness to share sensitive information with AI.

SURVEY

17 survey responses were collected from 17 unique participants.



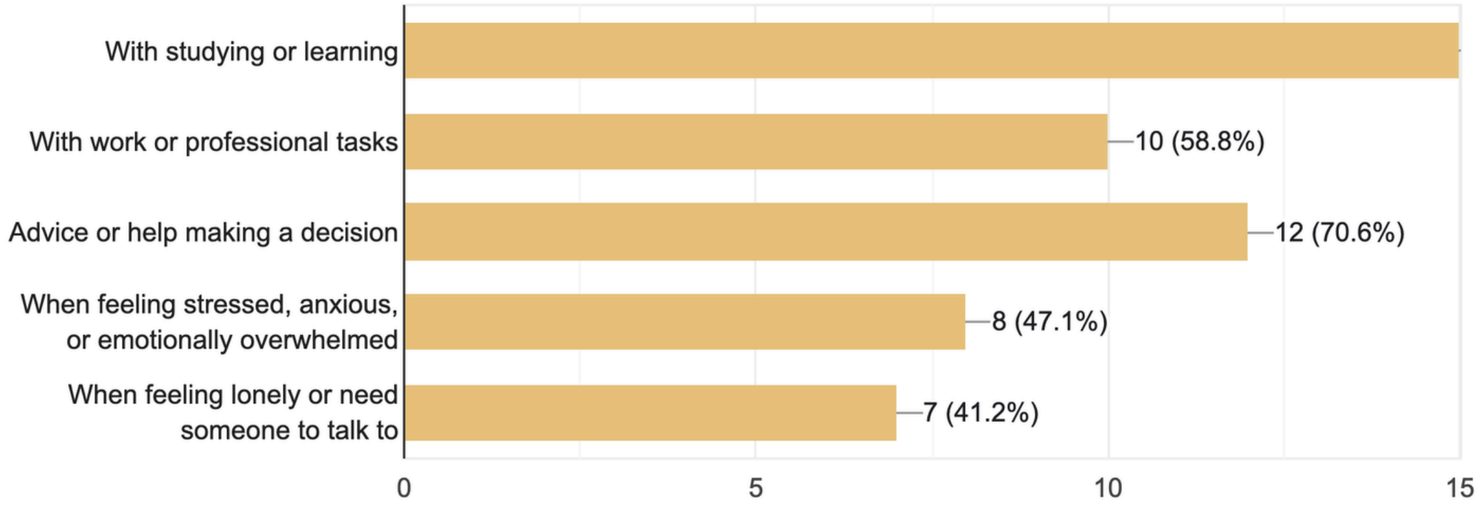




SURVEY

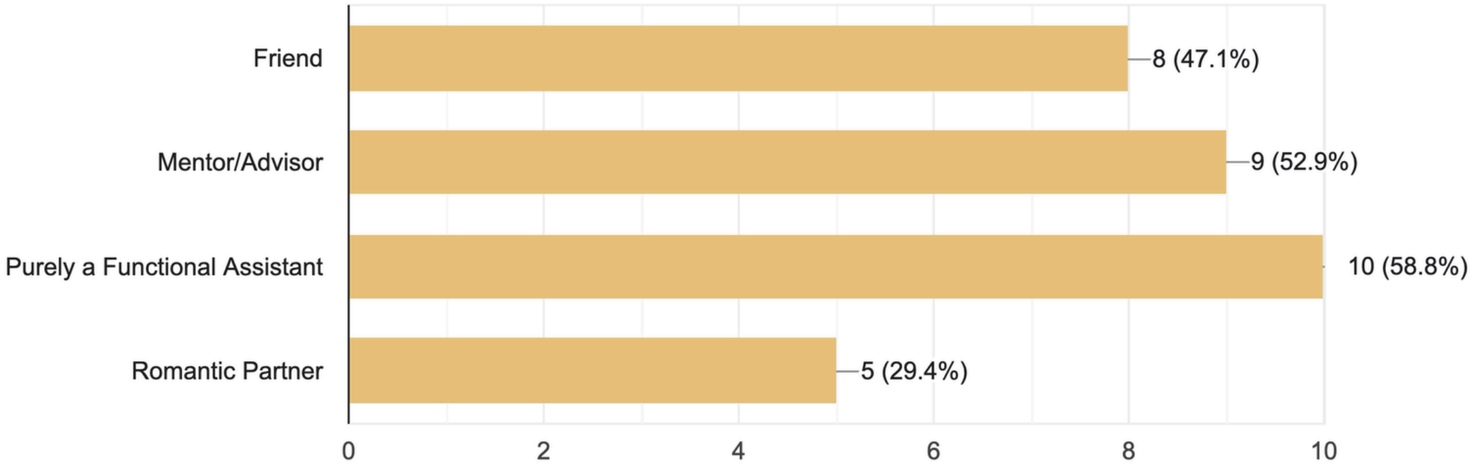
In which specific situations do you find yourself talking to your AI companion most often? (Check all that apply)

17 responses



How would you define your current relationship with your AI? (Check all that apply)

17 responses



WHAT DO THESE FINDINGS MEAN FOR OUR DESIGN?

1. Flexible Change Control

- Users have different preferences for AI initiation.
- Give users control over Conversation initiation.

2. Natural Transition

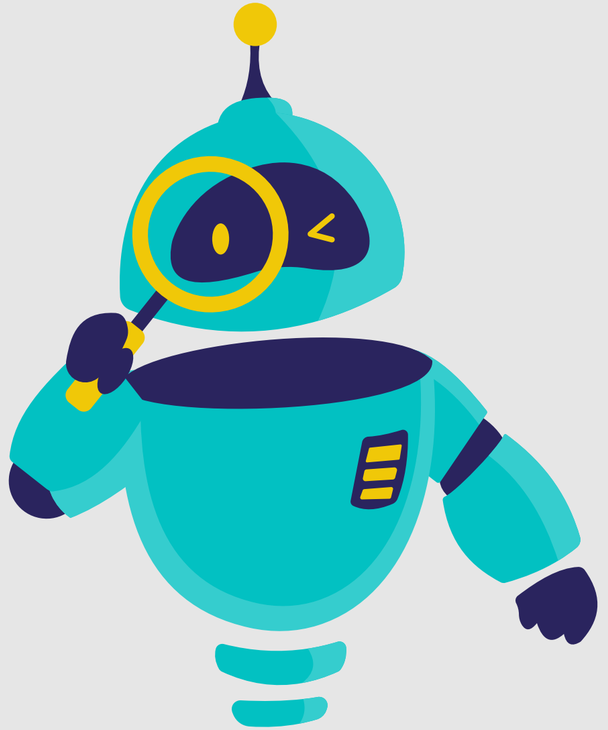
- Sudden Conversation shifts can feel awkward or unwanted.
- Make transitions gradual and non-forced.

3. Respect Boundaries

- Rejection should immediately stop romantic behaviour.
- No repeated requests or guilt-tripping.

4. Natural Consent

- Explicit pop-ups may feel too formal.
- Provide control without disrupting conversation.

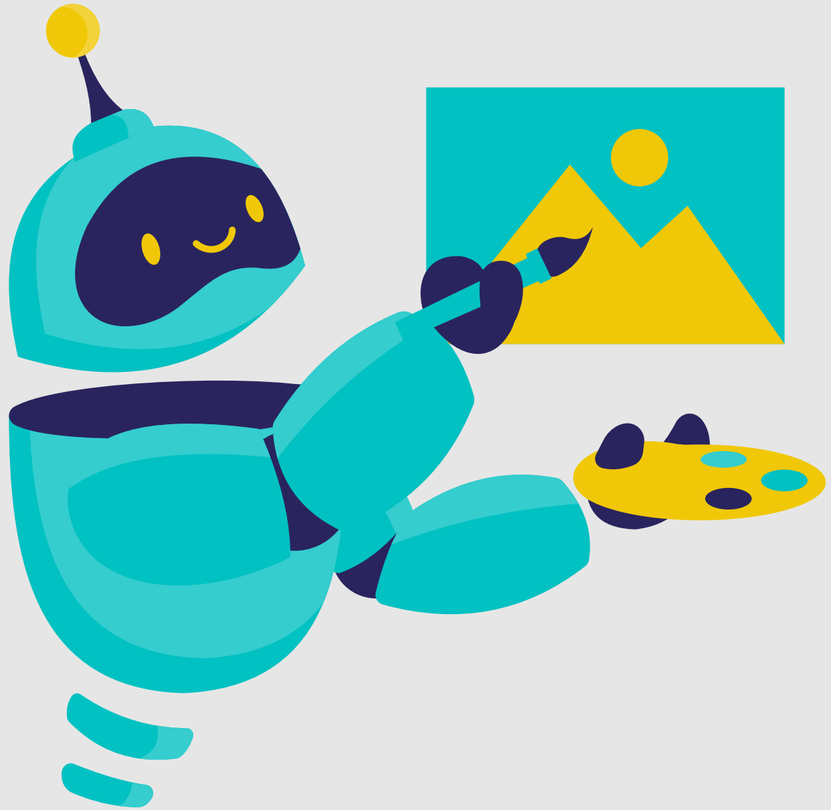


INITIAL DESIGN GOALS

1. **Relationship Control**
   Users control how the conversation is initiated.

2. **Consent**
   Clear, gradual, non-forced relationship shift.

3. **Easy Boundary Setting**
   Reject, stop, or return to older mood anytime.



THANK YOU